

We have also developed a rice variety that requires 30% less water. Water conservation and its efficient use are essential today. This rice variety won't require transplanting but can be sown directly, like wheat. You don't need to flood the fields and transplant by hand.

We need to bring high-quality seeds [to farmers] and need measures to reduce costs and increase production. For instance, today, farmers scatter urea by hand, which leads to uneven application. We will use drones and advanced technology to reduce fertiliser use and unnecessary expenses.

There are many ways to reduce costs. We have a well-planned strategy under the leadership of the PM... The Prime Minister said from the ramparts of the Red Fort that to build a developed India by 2047, he will work three times harder and faster. This makes us determined that we, too, will work three times harder and faster.

“The PM’s resolve and my dream is for India to become the world’s food basket. We will not just meet our own needs; we can also meet the world’s food needs”

SZ: When we talk about a population of 1.6 billion by 2047, where will the money to meet the demands for minimum support price (MSP) come from? Will we develop agriculture solely based on MSP, or is it time to think beyond it?

A: We need a balanced approach. If farming is unprofitable, how will the farmer survive? Just like no company can continue a business in losses, the farmer also needs two meals a day, money to educate their children, marry off their daughter, and other essential things.

I am proud to say that today, the PM Modi-led government has set MSP with a 50% profit over the cost. This never happened during the time of the Congress. They even stated in a Cabinet note that MSP could not be provided. MSP is essential, and I believe it should be given. But for the future, we should use methods that increase profitability... by using modern technology.

SZ: Do you think farmers have become victims of MSP politics as we have seen in the case of agricultural laws?

A: I believe the decision to provide MSP with a 50% profit over the cost by the Modi-led government is justified and fair. Farmers need to be given this.

The second point is that we do not always rely solely on MSP. Today, many wheat varieties fetch prices higher than MSP. Basmati rice prices are also above MSP. There are many instances of farmers not selling their produce at MSP because they get higher rates in the market. There is a misconception that MSP is needed everywhere; MSP is required only when market prices fall below it. In the future, if we use modern technology to increase production and reduce costs, profits will naturally increase. We need to produce crops that meet export standards.

Today, we are one of the Top 5 exporters [of agricultural goods] in the world. But when there is uncontrolled and excessive use of chemical fertilisers, our produce faces bans. Therefore, we must educate farmers to grow quality crops.

SZ: You hold two major ministries—rural development and agriculture. You also have a substantial budget that can directly benefit the population. What changes would you like to make?

A: Our growth rate in agriculture and horticulture is 4.6%, which shows the strength of the farming sector. During Covid-19, when the world was struggling, India's economy was largely unaffected because our farmers continued to work in the fields. The whole world witnessed the strength of Indian agriculture.

We have a well-planned strategy on agricultural diversification. There was a time when we had a tradition of multi-cropping... we are reviving that. Instead of relying solely on paddy cultivation, we are moving towards other crops. Many such experiments are taking place.

RK: The Haryana government announced it will pay MSP, but the Congress and the Samyukt Kisan Morcha say it is not sufficient. [Leader of the Opposition and Congress leader] Rahul Gandhi says his party will bring MSP as a legal guarantee, something that a section of the farmers also wants. What is your view?

A: If we look at the history of the Congress, their Prime Ministers, whom I respect a lot, rarely mentioned farmers and agriculture in their speeches from the Red Fort. From 1947 to 1950, the word 'farmers' was mentioned only once [during Independence Day